

Desert terrain

Deserts range widely in how they look. Soil forms very slowly and the land is often bare rock or gravel. Any loose, sandy soil may be blown into dunes. Sometimes, though, tough grasses or fleshy plants bind the soil together.



Dunes, or "sand seas"

Shifting mountains of sand can prevent plant growth.



Rock and gravel

Where no plants grow, the bedrock is often visible.



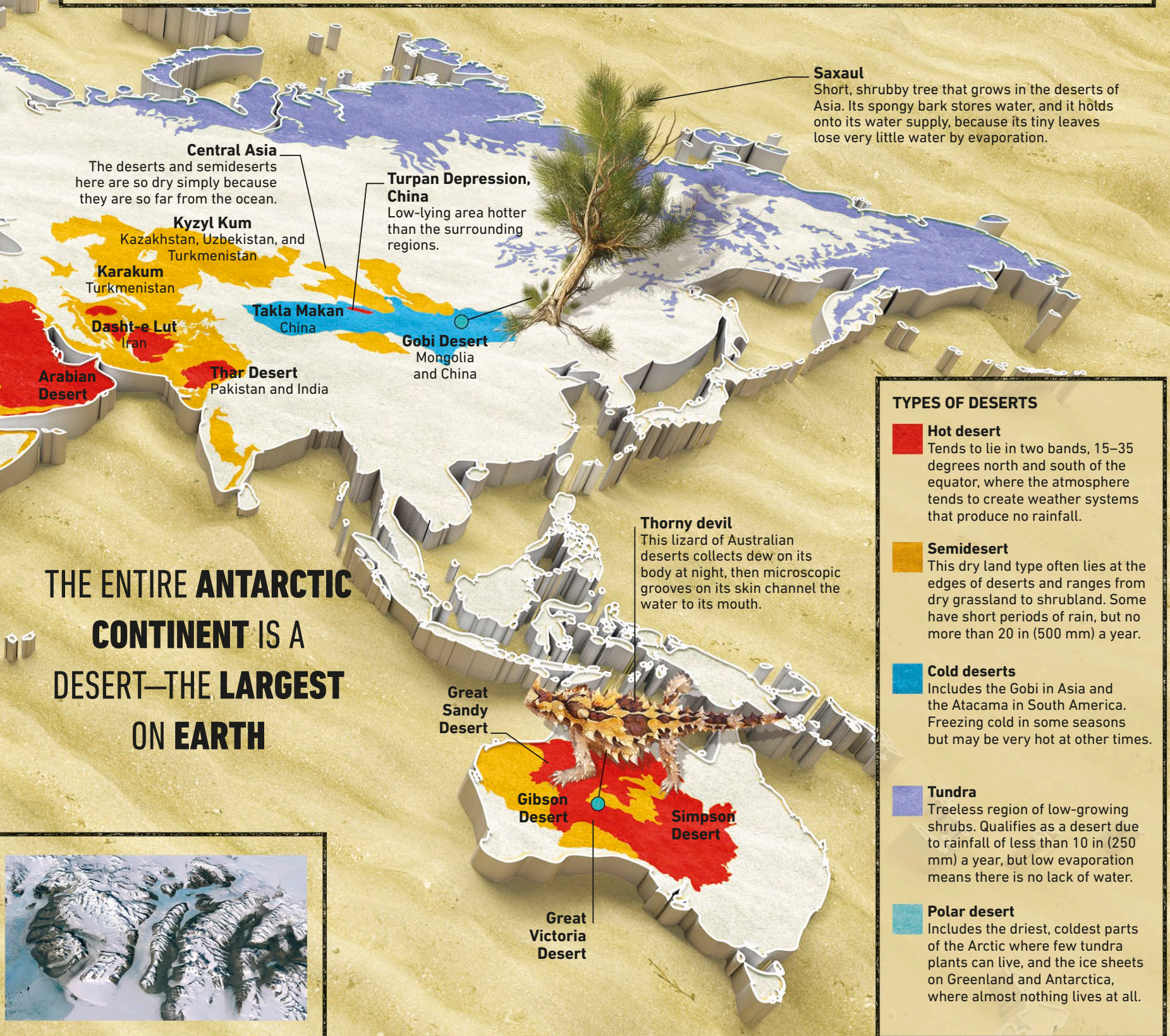
Dry grassland

Desert grasses can form soil and provide food for grazers.



Fleshy plants

Fleshy, water-storing plants may form thick vegetation.



THE ENTIRE **ANTARCTIC**
CONTINENT IS A
DESERT—THE **LARGEST**
ON EARTH

Saxaul

Short, shrubby tree that grows in the deserts of Asia. Its spongy bark stores water, and it holds onto its water supply, because its tiny leaves lose very little water by evaporation.

Central Asia

The deserts and semideserts here are so dry simply because they are so far from the ocean.

Kyzyl Kum

Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, and Turkmenistan

Karakum

Turkmenistan

Dasht-e Lut

Iran

Arabian Desert

Thar Desert

Pakistan and India

Turpan Depression, China

Low-lying area hotter than the surrounding regions.

Takla Makan

China

Gobi Desert

Mongolia and China

Thorny devil

This lizard of Australian deserts collects dew on its body at night, then microscopic grooves on its skin channel the water to its mouth.

Great Sandy Desert

Gibson Desert

Simpson Desert

Great Victoria Desert

TYPES OF DESERTS

Hot desert

Tends to lie in two bands, 15–35 degrees north and south of the equator, where the atmosphere tends to create weather systems that produce no rainfall.

Semidesert

This dry land type often lies at the edges of deserts and ranges from dry grassland to shrubland. Some have short periods of rain, but no more than 20 in (500 mm) a year.

Cold deserts

Includes the Gobi in Asia and the Atacama in South America. Freezing cold in some seasons but may be very hot at other times.

Tundra

Treeless region of low-growing shrubs. Qualifies as a desert due to rainfall of less than 10 in (250 mm) a year, but low evaporation means there is no lack of water.

Polar desert

Includes the driest, coldest parts of the Arctic where few tundra plants can live, and the ice sheets on Greenland and Antarctica, where almost nothing lives at all.